Placements handbook

2025/26

UNIVERSITY OF BATH

Contents

Welcome **3**

1 Support from the University and the Students' Union **4**
Faculty and School Placement Offices 4
Students' Union support whilst on placement 4
University services while on placement 5
Student money advice 6

2 SAMIS (PIMS) tasks **7**

3 Being on placement **8**
Employer contracts 8
University agreements: 3-way contracts 8
Are you ready for your first day? 8
Placement induction checklist 9
Supervision on placement 11
Communication –keeping in touch, problems and queries 11
Equality and diversity 12

4 Your responsibilities on placement **13**
Code of Conduct for students undertaking a placement 13
Registering with the University at the start of the academic year 13
Hours of work 14
Holidays 14
Sickness and sickness reporting 14

5 Practical information **15**
Accommodation 15
Advice for disabled students 16
Advice for international students 17
Health 17
Council tax, income tax and national insurance 18
Insurance for UK placements 19
Transport for London 19

6 Overseas placements **20**
Insurance and GHIC 20
Safety abroad 20
Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office Travel Update Service 21
Personal behaviour 22
Money 22
Cultural awareness 23
Tips for going abroad 25
Important documents 26
Document checklist 26

7 Being professional and effective **27**
Punctuality 27
Time management 28
Forms of address 29
Technology, internet and email 29
Dress code 29
Discipline and conduct 30
Intercultural awareness 30
Tackling problems on placement 31
At the end of your placement 34
Returning to university 34

Welcome

Going on placement will be an exciting and challenging experience. this resource is intended to provide guidance and support to all students undertaking a placement. Whilst out in industry you still very much remain part of the university.

It will give you general advice and information on how best to prepare and organise yourself beforehand, and some useful guidance to help you for when you are settling into your placement.

1 Support from the University and the Students' Union

Faculty and School Placement Offices

Your Faculty or School Placement Offices should be your first point of contact for any matter related to your placement experience.

Whether you have a quick question about your experience or would like to talk in confidence to a member of the team, they are here to help.

You will have specific Moodle placement support pages but please see below for contact details for your Placement Teams:

Faculty of Engineering & Design:
go.bath.ac.uk/engineering-placement

Faculty of Humanities & Social Sciences:
go.bath.ac.uk/HSS-placements-team

School of Management:
www.bath.ac.uk/teams/school-of-management-employability-team

Faculty of Science:
go.bath.ac.uk/science-placements-team

THE SU BATH

Students' Union support whilst on placement

Whilst you are on placement, you are a registered student and, as such, are entitled to make use of the full range of support services offered by the Students' Union

The SU Advice and Support Centre

The SU Advice & Support Centre provide independent, confidential advice to students on placement, including:

- Academic appeals, IMCs, and complaints
- Housing contracts and landlord complaints
- Reporting harassment, discrimination, and assault
- Responding to University disciplinaries

Contact: **suadvice@bath.ac.uk**
Virtual appointments available **Monday-Friday**.

Students' Union membership

You are still a member of The Students' Union whilst on placement once you have re-registered with the University. You can attend events, join clubs and societies and take advantage of any training and development opportunities where applicable.

thesubath.com

Elections and representation

Students who are currently on placement have the same rights to stand and vote in SU elections. Details of all SU elections can be found at **thesubath.com/elections**

Off campus support

Take a look at this dedicated web page for all the support you can get whilst off campus: **thesubath.com/support/off-campus**

University services while on placement

You are entitled to make use of the full range of support services offered by the University. This includes:

Student support

Student Support & Safeguarding provides advice on a range of issues including:

- Mental Health & Wellbeing Needs
- Disability Advice
- Money Advice
- Support for Care Leavers and Estranged students

We will support all students whether they are on campus or on placement, and can provide support to you wherever you are. Students can complete an online self-referral form to be directed to the most appropriate team for support by following the web-links below.

While you are on placement, we know it may be more difficult to attend appointments in person. All services can provide support over the phone or via Microsoft Teams. We can't provide support at evenings and weekends but will do our best to find you an appointment that works for you.

You can also access the Be Well app which has a range of self-help resources, useful podcasts and articles.

Contact details:
go.bath.ac.uk/student-services

studentsupport@bath.ac.uk

+44 (0)1225 383838

BE Well – Talk Now

You can talk to a counsellor about any issues or problems you're facing 24 hours a day 7 days a week, 365 days a year. This is a service offered via Student Support & Safeguarding who can support you with personal issues, legal or financial queries, and anything else that is impacting your wellbeing.

You can get support via phone or live chat no matter where you are in the world.

If you are outside of the UK calls will be chargeable, but you can instead request a call back. If you would like to request a call back to avoid call charges please email **counsellingadvice@healthassured.co.uk** with your name, contact number, and a time of when you would like a call in the next 48 hours. Alternatively, you can call the number and inform the Advisor on the call you would like a call back.

To speak to an adviser for support about any issues you may be facing:

From within the UK: 0800 028 3766

From outside the UK: +44 800 085 2570

www.bath.ac.uk/campaigns/be-well-talk-now/

Letter confirming student status

You may need a letter saying you are a registered full time student. Typically, this will be for exemption from Council Tax, but could also be for access to other libraries, accessing student discount etc. You can request a letter by logging into SAMIS

samis.bath.ac.uk

Make sure you have updated your current contact address to reflect where you are living on placement in order for the University to generate the correct letter.

If you have completed your Student Loan Company (SLC) online form correctly when applying for your loan then you will NOT need a letter for the SLC. You will only need a letter for the SLC if you are applying for your loan to come early (before Oct).

University email account

It is essential that you access and read your University email regularly, and always use this e-mail address for communication that is University related. In accordance with the University regulation we send you important information relating to deadlines, registration, and assessment to this email address only. It can be useful to set up the Outlook app on your phone.

go.bath.ac.uk/email-and-calendar

Use of University Library on placement

You can access all of the University of Bath Library's online resources off campus with your Computing Services login. The Library staff are available to support you while you are on placement. Ask for help online at:
go.bath.ac.uk/ask-a-librarian

The Bath Copies service will send scanned extracts of books and journals that are not in the Library's online collection. There is a standard fee for each request.
go.bath.ac.uk/bathcopies

You can borrow books from other university libraries in the UK:
go.bath.ac.uk/other-libraries

Chaplaincy

During term time there is usually a chaplain available Monday to Thursday between 8.30 and at least 17:00.

Tel: **+44 (0)1225 386458**
Duty Chaplain**: +44 (0)7966 341370**
Email: **chaplaincy@bath.ac.uk**

Student money advice

Before choosing to undertake a placement, please ensure that you have the necessary funding in place and can afford to cover the essential costs of a placement. If you do encounter financial difficulties whilst away on placement then you can contact **studentmoneyadvice@bath.ac.uk**

Tuition fees

Tuition fees for the placement year are due in September when you re-register (this is done online). The placement year carries a reduced tuition fee and these fees are reviewed annually. For more information about tuition fees, see the Student Finance website:

go.bath.ac.uk/tuition-fees

University of Bath Financial Support Fund

The University of Bath Financial Support Fund is a discretionary fund and can provide financial assistance to students who are experiencing financial difficulty. Students on placement are expected to have their essential costs such as rent, food & utility bills covered before being considered for an award.

www.bath.ac.uk/guides/applying-for-the-university-of-bath-financial-support-fund/

Alumni fund grants:

Alumni Fund Grants: Applications for Alumni Fund Placement Grants are considered from individual students requesting personal funding, for a placement that is unpaid or low paid or paid only a modest stipend. Please see webpage for deadlines.

The Turing Scheme provides funding to support international mobility costs, but it is limited and not guaranteed.

go.bath.ac.uk/alumni-placement-grants

Your finances

Generally, you will receive a reduced rate of student loan whilst on placement, unless you are undertaking specific types of research or Type B unpaid service placements. Check with your Student Finance provider e.g. England, Wales, Scotland or Northern Ireland whether or not the type of placement you are undertaking qualifies for full statutory support. Placement funding information:

go.bath.ac.uk/placement-finances

2 SAMIS (PIMS) tasks

Once you have informed your placements team about your placement you will begin to receive tasks via email which will direct you to your SAMIS in-tray.

Completion of these tasks provides us with vital information about your placement, including the following:

- Additional support questionnaire
- Consent to share information
- Contract confirmation
- 3-Way agreement task (you will need to complete this if your company is not providing a contract)
- Placement confirmation
- Overseas placements risk awareness questionnaire (if required)
- Salary & mode of attendance

Other tasks will be sent to you after you start your placement, including:

- Accommodation and contact details
- Supervisor/HR manager details
- Working hours
- Health and safety questionnaire
- End date confirmation

You will also periodically be sent questionnaires asking about your progress and wellbeing. If you notify us of any problems in these questionnaires your Placement Officer will contact you to offer their support.

Please ensure you complete all the tasks that are sent to you in a timely fashion. These tasks are vital so you can provide us with the required information for your placements programme. They will also help to ensure that your records are kept up to date and that you get the best support possible.

3 Being on placement

The following section has practical advice for things you need to do and which may help you during your placement.

Employer contracts

Please ensure that you check through the terms and conditions of your contract carefully. Guidelines can be found at: **gov.uk/employment-contracts-and-conditions**

Your hours of work should be written into your contract and comply with Working Time Regulations 1998. Some employers such as financial institutions, or consultancies or start-ups may expect employees to work long hours and this is part of the culture of the sector. They may ask you to sign a contract/agreement where you opt out of the usual right to work no more than 48 hours over a seven day period. Consider this carefully as it is often normal practice in the industry you have chosen but you can exercise your right to opt out of such an agreement. If your contract contains this type of clause, please ensure that you read through the advice provided at: **gov.uk/maximum-weekly-working-hours**

Should you have any concerns about the terms and conditions of your contract, you should raise these directly with your placement provider. You can also go to a **Citizens Advice Bureau** to get individual advice on your contract, or access legal advice through the **National Union of Students (NUS)**.

University agreements: 3-way contracts

These are only required if your placement provider is unable to issue you with an employment contract. The University agreement must be signed by your placement provider, a member of staff from your placements team or Department, and you must also sign the agreement. You must provide your placements support team with the University agreement to check before you sign it. The University must keep a copy of all 3-way contracts, and it is your responsibility to ensure that you have provided your placement support team with a copy of the final agreement.

Are you ready for your first day?

When you arrive at your place of work, there will undoubtedly be a number of things you are unclear about. Everybody gets that feeling of being the new person, but remember that everyone was new once and that there are steps you can take to make your first days and weeks feel easier.

Be prepared -
think about what you might need with you, e.g. a notepad and pen.

First impressions count -
you only get one chance to make a first impression. Be focused & professional from the start.

Be enthusiastic and get involved -
grab whatever opportunities come your way!

Where and how -
know where you are going and how to get there –check buses, timetables, parking maps etc.

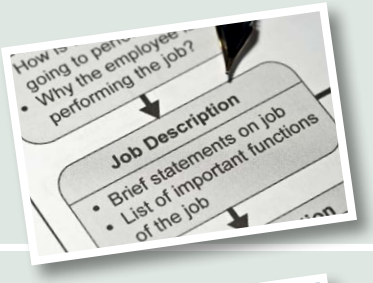
What to wear?
Is there a dress code? Check with your supervisor BEFORE you start.

Be punctual -
plan your journey so you can arrive feeling calm and ready for the day.

Placement induction checklist

This checklist is provided as a guide to areas which may be covered during the induction to the company and your job. It will also act as a reminder to your colleagues of what should happen, or what you should be told as you join them. Your induction may be slightly different if conducted remotely. If you move from remote working to on-site part-way through a placement, please ensure your on-site induction is completed at that point.

- Check off each item, if relevant to your employment, as you feel it has been covered or when you have been given the required information.
- As you settle in you will be able to discuss your role, personal objectives and further training with your supervisors.
- Flag up any aspects which you feel have not been completed with your supervisor or Human Resources Office.
- Contact your Placements Team if you still have concerns.



1 Your job

- [ ] Department's role and mission
- [ ] Your job explained in relation to the Department's mission
- [ ] Clarification of your job description - is this the same as discussed at interview?
- [ ] Payroll dates explained, relevant documents submitted

2 Department organisation

- [ ] Organisational chart for the Department (Who's who)
- [ ] Familiarisation with company policies & initiatives
- [ ] Hours of work and flexi-time
- [ ] Meal break/cover arrangements
- [ ] Holiday arrangements
- [ ] Sickness notification and procedure
- [ ] Dress Code
- [ ] Probation period & procedure
- [ ] Personal Development Plans / Appraisal systems (introduce the University system)

3 Work space, equipment & systems

- [ ] Desk & Chair
- [ ] Storage of personal belongings
- [ ] Computer with software installed
- [ ] Print procedures
- [ ] Rules on use of equipment
- [ ] Telephone & extension number
- [ ] Telephone management/voicemail
- [ ] Basic stationery & office/desk necessities
- [ ] An email address
- [ ] Username & passwords
- [ ] Access to systems and networks
- [ ] Access and addition to mailing lists & contact details
- [ ] Office key, security access & policies
- [ ] Car parking places/permits

4 People

- [ ] Have you been allocated a supervisor?
- [ ] Have you been allocated a separate mentor or ‘buddy’?
- [ ] Have you discussed any extra needs with a placement supervisor?
- [ ] Introduction to your supervisor
- [ ] Introduction to line manager if different
- [ ] Introduction to key colleagues/co-workers

- [ ] **Department layout**
- [ ] Tour of premises and Department
- [ ] Entrances and Exits (including Emergency Exits and Assembly Points) Canteen, refreshments and kitchens
- [ ] Location of toilets, washing and shower facilities

Location of break areas

- [ ] **Working safely** (*see below)
- [ ] Health & Safety Induction with word policies and procedures explained Safety policy received or awareness of its location
- [ ] Who is the Health & Safety Officer?
- [ ] Fire drill & alarm procedures
- [ ] Fire extinguishers: location and use
- [ ] Local safety hazards: risk assessments
- [ ] Accident reporting procedures
- [ ] First Aid and names/location of First Aiders
- [ ] Display screen/workstation regulations and procedures
- [ ] Protective clothing and equipment where appropriate

Manual Handling procedure where appropriate

- [ ] **Training**
- [ ] Training on IT systems & networks

Instruction on equipment you will be using

***Working Safely:**
For the purposes of employment law, including health and safety at work, students on placement in the UK are classed as employees whether or not they are paid for the work they are doing. The Health and Safety (Training for Employment) Regulations 1990 give students on work placement the same protection and duties as employees under the Health and Safety at Work Act 1974. Therefore, the placement provider has the duty of care and responsibility for the health and safety of the student while the student is at work. The student is also insured while at work under the provisions of the Employers’ Liability Insurance.

Supervision on placement

Your line manager/supervisor will be the person to answer any queries, help you settle in and support you with your placement work. However, depending on workload, they may assign another member of their team to supervise you on a daily basis.

You should:

- ensure that you have **regular meetings** with your manager/supervisor - you may want to set a particular day and time - to review your progress and receive feedback
- **plan your meetings** in advance so that you can discuss matters that are on your mind
- liaise with your supervisor when you set **objectives** for yourself at the start of the placement, and make sure that you get a final review before you leave. It is always a valuable exercise to review your time on placement and to assess its relevance to your academic work
- discuss with your line manager if you need extra support

One of the key tasks is for you to learn to work independently and to plan your time, especially if you are working on several projects or for several people at once. You will need to:

- work out how to prioritise work and tasks to meet deadlines
- ask for clarification if you are unsure of what is expected
- be prepared to update your supervisor on work you have completed and what you plan to do next

Communication –keeping in touch, problems and queries

It is a requirement that you **keep in regular contact** with your Visiting Tutor* whilst you are away from the University - they are always interested to hear from you about your placement.

Your Placement Team will contact you throughout the year via **Moodle** posts or your University of Bath **email** – please remember to **check it regularly** and to keep your inbox empty. We will only use your work email if we need to contact you on the same day or urgently.

Visits - If you are on placement of one semester or longer you should have at least one virtual meeting, or in person visit, by a representative of the University.

Please remember you can access help for any personal problems from student support & safeguarding.

Problem on placement? If this cannot be resolved with your employer, please contact your Placement Tutor. You can also contact the Advice and Support Centre in The SU for support.

Query about the placement/requirements? First, check this handbook or your Moodle course – most of the information you need is available from these resources, particularly relating to forms, reports etc. However, if you have any further queries, contact your Placements Team and they will try to answer them as soon as possible.

*Terminology varies across Departments/Faculties/Schools but 'Placement Tutor' refers to the individual assigned to you to provide support during placement; this may be an Academic, Placement or academic adviser or a member of the Placements team.

Equality and diversity

If you encounter any kind of discrimination whilst on your placement, **do not assume that you cannot do anything about it.** The Students' Union or the University can support you and help you to sort out the situation. It may be well worth asking for a copy of the company's equal opportunities statement and policy when starting your placement.

The defining features of harassment are that the **behaviour is unwanted by the recipient and would be regarded as harassment by any reasonable person.**

Everyone at the University of Bath has a responsibility for:

- promoting equality
- fostering good relations between all members of the community, staff and students
- eliminating unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation against anyone for reasons of:
  - Age
  - Disability
  - Gender reassignment
  - Marriage and civil partnership
  - Race
  - Religion or belief
  - Sex
  - Sexual orientation

Sexual harassment can include*

- suggestive or derogatory remarks
- unnecessary and unwelcome physical contact
- displaying offensive material (e.g. pornography)
- unwelcome requests for sexual encounters
- written abuse
- indecent exposure
- sexual/physical assault

Racial harassment can include

- verbal or written abuse
- racist graffiti or symbols
- derogatory name calling
- insults or jokes
- racist assumptions
- exclusion from social conversation or events
- ridicule of an individual for cultural differences
- threats or physical attack

Other forms of discrimination or harassment include**

- persistent teasing
- homophobic remarks
- comments about personal characteristics
- comments about disabilities
- unfounded criticism of performance
- persistent phone calls, electronic mail or letters

* Associated with sexual harassment is: explicit or implicit promised rewards for cooperation; explicit or implicit threats of punishment or penalty; intimidation creating a hostile or offensive environment.

** This can be because of religious beliefs; age; health; past criminal record; physical/ mental disability; being diagnosed as HIV positive; or responsibilities for dependants.

You can report harassment, assault or discrimination to the Students' Union or the University via the Report and Support tool. **bath.ac.uk/campaigns/support-and-report**

We recommend you complete our #NeverOK Module for students on placements, internships or exchanges. **go.bath.ac.uk/neverok-moodle**

or Contact Equality and Diversity:
+44 (0)1225 383098 or email **equalsdiv@bath.ac.uk** / **diversity@bath.ac.uk**

or the The SU Advice and Support Centre:
+44 (0)1225 386906 or email **suadvice@bath.ac.uk**

For more information see:
go.bath.ac.uk/equality-diversity-inclusion

4 Your responsibilities on placement

Code of Conduct for students undertaking a placement

Your individual Placements Team will be able to provide you with the full code of conduct for students undertaking a placement. Please disclose to staff if you are experiencing challenges with your health and wellbeing. The key points to note are:

You should:
- be aware that you will need to prepare for and show commitment to your placement as soon as you accept a role (verbal acceptance is still formal acceptance)
- make full use of individual departmental and central University assistance and support
- understand and adhere to any assessment requirements for placement
- attend all required placement briefings and debriefings organised by individual and central University departments
- remember that you are representing yourself and the University whilst on placement and should always behave appropriately at work and outside of work
- Be aware that everyone at Bath has a responsibility to promote equality and eliminate unlawful discrimination, which still applies during your time on placement
- Realise it is your responsibility to find a suitable placement by the due date

Be aware of your rights to:
- an appropriate learning experience
- a safe working environment
- be treated in accordance with applicable legislation
- be employed under a contract. Contact your Placements Office if your organisation has not provided you with one.

Once placed but prior to commencement, you should:
- submit promptly all requested details and paperwork to your Placements Office
- recognise that it is your responsibility to find suitable placement accommodation
- comply with all reasonable requests from the employer and inform your Placements Office of any changes
- withdraw from any other outstanding applications or interviews in a polite and professional manner

During placement, you should:
- take every opportunity to optimise your learning experience
- complete contact information and paperwork requested by the department within the set timeframe
- act within the terms and conditions laid down by your placement provider and comply with relevant Health and Safety regulations
- not give notice to your placement provider without first consulting your Placements Team
- inform your Placement Officer/ Visiting Tutor and Placements Team of any problems that cannot be resolved in the workplace
- before finishing your placement, ensure all requirements of both placement provider and department have been met

Registering with the University at the start of the academic year

Although you are on placement, you are still a student of the University. Therefore, you must register online at the start of the academic year - **bath.ac.uk/guides/registering-with-the-university/**

You must ensure that the University holds correct, up-to-date, personal and academic details for you. Failure to register by the specified deadline at the start of each academic year will mean that your access to University email and Moodle will be temporarily disabled until you register.

Hours of work

- Determined in conjunction with your supervisor/line manager/HR contact
- Please remember that some degree programmes have specific requirements regarding the number of hours/weeks you need to undertake in order to successfully complete the placement year
- Your hours of work should be written into your contract and comply with Working Time Regulations 1998

Some employers such as financial institutions or motorsport expect employees to work long hours and this is part of the culture of the sector. They may ask you to sign a contract/agreement where you opt out of the usual right to work no more than 48 hours over a seven day period. Consider this carefully as it is often normal practice in the industry you have chosen but you can exercise your right to opt out of such an agreement. If you have any concerns regarding your hours of work, please contact the Citizens Advice Bureau or ACAS for support: **www.acas.org.uk/working-hours** | **If you're working too many hours - Citizens Advice**

Holidays

Most placement organisations offer paid* annual leave. This does vary across employers, but is normally equivalent to four weeks a year (i.e. 20 working days) but pro rota if you work less than a year. You are also entitled to Bank or National Holidays, unless you are working on a rota/ shift system e.g. hospital or similar public service, in which case you may have to cover some public holidays and may have additional pay or time off in lieu. If you are uncertain, check your contract or letter of appointment or contact your Human Resources department.

Most companies will have a system in place for requesting leave. Arrange your holidays well in advance with the agreement of your manager, even for occasional days off. Remember that you are expected to behave as an employee and not as a student, and to fit in with the needs of the employer/department.

* If your placement is unpaid, you are still entitled to annual leave and your contract or placement agreement will state the number of days of holiday you are entitled to.

Sickness and sickness reporting

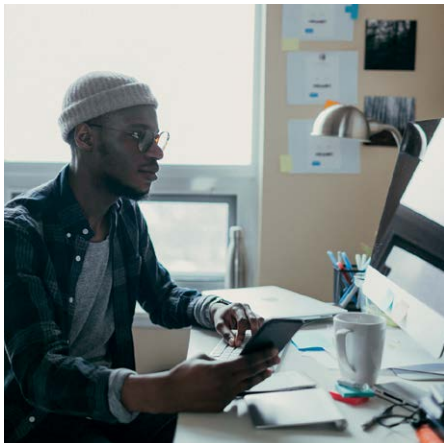
Feeling unwell?	• inform your employer immediately (by phone, not email) • ask if they require a doctor's certificate • keep your employer up-dated throughout your illness as to how ill you are and when you expect to return to work. Your employer will want to know that your illness is genuine.
3 or more days off sick?	• inform your Placements Office and keep them up to date
More than 7 calendar days of absence?	• you must obtain a 'fit note' (MED3 Form) from your GP • **www.gov.uk/taking-sick-leave**

Pay during illness - You are not legally entitled to full pay while you are sick, but you may be entitled to Statutory Sick Pay* (SSP); check your contract with HR. If for some reason you do not qualify for SSP, you may be entitled to claim sickness benefits.

* applicable to UK and paid placements only

See the following links for more information:
gov.uk/statutory-sick-pay/overview
gov.uk/financial-help-disabled/disability-and-sickness-benefits
If you encounter difficulties contact Student Money Advice:
+44 (0)1225 383838 or email **studentmoneyadvice@bath.ac.uk**

5 Practical information



Accommodation

One of the most important things to find out before placement is where you will be living, what accommodation is available and how much it will cost.

If you are living in a large city accommodation may be expensive. Ensure that you have good access to public transport and that the area is well lit at night.

It is your responsibility to find suitable accommodation within reasonable commuting distance of your place of work.

The Placement teams share placement provider name and location on the **'Placement and Exchanges Location Map'** for students who give permission for their details to be shared. To access this you must be logged onto Eduroam, a University desktop or using Uniapps/Unidesk. Please do use this to organise house shares, ask your new employer if they can help with finding housing. Are there any other students who might want a house share, or are any students leaving, meaning a room may become free?

If you are going abroad
Ask your company or organisation whether or not they can arrange for some short term accommodation for your arrival until you have had a chance to find your own place.
Do not pay a deposit on accommodation that you have only seen on the internet; wait until you arrive and have visited. Have a self-catering accommodation (such as an Airbnb) or hostel booked before you leave the UK, so that when you arrive you have somewhere to sleep and leave your belongings whilst you look for a room/flat/house.

If you will be in Britain
Try to visit the area you will want to live in before you start to find your accommodation.

Websites to utilise to help you with your search:

unitestudents.com
loot.com
gumtree.com
spareroom.co.uk
zoopla.co.uk
housinganywhere.com

Please note, the University cannot guarantee the quality or endorse what is posted on these accommodation websites.

The SU Advice & Support Centre can look through your contract and answer any queries. You can contact them via email at **suadvice@bath.ac.uk.** Virtual appointments available Monday-Friday.

Safety checks for accommodation

Remember that the quality and standard of accommodation can vary. In the UK there are strict regulations on gas, electrical and fire safety, but these may not exist in other countries. As the University cannot physically inspect accommodation for you we ask you to identify the following possible risks to you and to consider these suggestions:

- Is there an appropriate level of security including: locks to external/entrance doors and windows?
- Does your personal space (bedroom) have a suitable lock on the door, and are there locks on the inside of the bathroom/toilet doors?
- Are all gas appliances checked and serviced at least annually by a competent person?
- Are there appropriate fire precautions in place e.g. smoke detectors and means of fighting fires?
- Have all electrical wiring, sockets etc. been maintained in a safe condition and all electrical appliances been tested and maintained for safety as appropriate?

Personal Safety, Top Tip

- You could carry a personal alarm
- Try not to go out alone at night
- Carry enough money for a taxi; only use registered taxis

Advice for disabled students

The University is committed to supporting all disabled students who choose to undertake placements and their placement providers.

Disabled Students allowance/reasonable adjustments
If you receive Disabled Students allowance (DSA) (UK students only), you might not have access to this allowance if you are on an unpaid placement in the UK, but please speak to the Disability Adviser to check this.

If you need support on placement because of a disability, then please discuss with your Placement Officer first, and then with your placement provider, to share your condition and potential adjustments that they could put in place. You may be entitled to reasonable adjustments to access work, even if you are not in receipt of DSA funding.

If you secure a one-year paid placement, you might not be able to access DSA support while on placement. If you need reasonable adjustments made, you may be eligible for Access to Work funding. Full details about this are here: gov.uk/access-to-work. Through the Access to Work website, you can contact an Access to Work Advisor who will assess your needs, discuss possible workplace adjustments and modifications and liaise with the employer if necessary. They can then arrange for funding to be made available.

Sometimes, simply changing a work pattern having protected time allocated for appointments, moving a desk or other small adjustments are all that is needed and can be achieved without funding. Therefore, it would be best if you can discuss your needs and potential adjustments with your placement provider first. The placement provider will need time to implement any changes before the start of the placement, therefore we encourage you to discuss reasonable adjustments with your placement provider as early as possible.

Should you need to still apply to Access to Work, please discuss this with your placement provider first, as there might be costs payable by your provider. Some companies will also offer access to their Employee Assistance Programme (EAP). If you need support with these conversations, please contact your Placement Officer.

The earliest point at which Access to Work can begin to help is six weeks before the start of the placement, but once contacted, they will act promptly.

The University Careers Team has a specialist adviser who can also help support students with disabilities with information and advice: **+44 (0)1225 386009** or email **careers@bath.ac.uk / bath.ac.uk/careers**

See more information on employment and disability matters here:
bath.ac.uk/students/careers/equalities/index.html

Placements overseas
If you are doing a placement abroad, be aware that disability policies and disability support can vary widely. Access to Work funding is not available for work outside the UK. Check with your department and the Disability Advice team about what support you are entitled to before going overseas.

Support while on placement
If you develop or have a disability identified whilst on placement, please make an appointment to see a Student Disability Adviser who can advise about potential support and how to apply for it.

Advice for international students

Students holding a tier 4/student visa
Although you will be away from the University, our responsibilities as your tier 4/student visa sponsor remain the same. Your responsibilities to comply with the conditions of your tier 4/student visa and to inform the University of any changes remain the same.

We are required to continue to monitor your engagement with your placement in line with the University's Engagement Monitoring Policy. You will be required to attend an information session with the Student Immigration Service to cover the visa requirements whilst you are on placement. Throughout your placement you will be contacted by email by the University and you must ensure that you reply as requested.

If you need to be absent you must inform your employer. If you need to be absent for more than 14 days you must also request an authorised absence through SAMIS: **www.bath.ac.uk/services/samis**

A letter will be sent to placement providers hosting tier 4/student visa students to clarify the University's responsibilities as a sponsor and the visa rules.

Should you fail to engage with your studies, the University may no longer be able to act as your tier 4/student visa sponsor and your tier 4/student visa may be curtailed.

Students requiring further information about their visa, or who may need to make a visa extension, should contact the Student Immigration Service by logging an enquiry through the Student Services Helpdesk (SAMIS) before beginning their placement. Please note you may be required to make your visa extension overseas.

Work Permits
It should be noted that work permits are not required if the placement forms a formal part of the degree. However, we recommend you check with the Student Immigration Service for up-to-date guidance regarding work permits.

Health

Free prescriptions, UK ONLY
If you have a low income, the NHS Low Income Scheme could help you pay for, NHS prescription charges, NHS dental treatment and sight tests. To find out if you are eligible go to **nhsbsa.nhs.uk/help-nhs-prescription-costs/free-nhs-prescriptions**

Doctors
REGISTER WITH A LOCAL GP - Do not wait until you are ill. Names and addresses are held at the main post offices, or see **nhs.uk/Service-Search/GP/LocationSearch/4** to find a GP in the UK. You do not need a doctor's certificate for the first seven days of illness, but after that, you will need a certificate. Follow company guidelines on illness and their procedures for reporting absence due to illness.

Mental Health
If you have any concerns about your mental health while on placement, then you can speak to your GP. Your placement employer may also offer employee benefits which include counselling support, so please speak to your placement supervisor about this. You can also access support from the University **go.bath.ac.uk/therapeutic-services**

Dental Treatment
Register with a dental centre. Do not wait until you have a problem with your teeth. You can check here whether dentists are taking on NHS patients **www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-a-dentist**. If you are not treated as an NHS patient then you may be treated as a private patient and have to pay the full cost.

Council tax, income tax and national insurance

Council tax
In the UK, under current legislation, houses occupied only by students are "exempt dwellings" and are therefore NOT liable for Council Tax. You should contact the local Council Tax Office when you move in to inform them of your student status. They will need to see written evidence of this. Request a proof of student status letter to apply for council tax exemption by logging onto SAMIS **www.bath.ac.uk/services/samis**; it will be posted to you.

If there are students and non-students living in your property, it is more complicated. If there is only one non-student living in the property, a 25% sole occupier discount is applicable. This is because the students are treated as 'invisible'. A property with more than one non-student living in it will qualify to pay the full amount of council tax. It is very important that if you are going to be living with one or more non-students that you decide who will be paying this bill. Students are treated as invisible when calculating the tax, but your housemates may find it unfair for you not to contribute.

It is worth remembering that non-students may be able to claim Council Tax Benefit if they are on a low income.

If you have any difficulties/queries on matters such as Tax, National Insurance, Council Tax then contact The SU Advice and Support Centre on: **suadvice@bath.ac.uk** or Student Money Advice on: **studentmoneyadvice@bath.ac.uk** / +44 (0)1225 385538 who are experienced in helping students with these issues.

Income tax
If you have been employed before make sure you take your P45 with you when you start work, and keep all your pay-slips showing deductions in case you qualify for a tax rebate. Obtain your P45 from your employer at the end of your placement as this shows the total tax paid. You may wish to claim tax rebate so keep this P45 in a safe place. If you have not been employed before, you will need to complete a Starter Checklist that your employer will provide -see **www.hmrc.gov.uk/students**

National insurance (NI)
If you are earning over a certain amount per week you will have a percentage of your wages deducted by your employer to pay National Insurance contributions. These contributions will make it more likely that you will be able to receive certain benefits in the future. Both you and your employer make contributions and the percentage varies according to your earnings.

If the firm you work for has an occupational pension scheme and you are part of this, you may be able to pay a lower percentage. However, the contribution to the company scheme and NI is likely to be higher than NI alone. Retirement benefits earned in one year of contributions to a company scheme are unlikely to be high: check carefully to see whether joining the company scheme will be worthwhile, as you will be able to "opt-out" if you wish.

Obtaining a national insurance number - overseas students
Overseas students who have not worked in Britain before and who are undertaking their placement here will need to obtain a National Insurance (NI) number. It may be that National Insurance contributions you make can be credited to your own country's social security or pension scheme.

To get an NI number you should apply online, for free, via the government website **gov.uk/apply-national-insurance-number.** This should take 3-6 weeks, although it may take up to 3 months at busy times of year.

You can work without a NI number, but you should supply it to your employer as soon as you receive it. It may be worthwhile checking this with your placement provider as some employers do ask for a NI number before you start.

Insurance for UK placements

There are a number of insurance related issues to consider before starting a placement. The following are some of the things which can go wrong and how insurance can help to put things right.

What if you need medical assistance?
If your placement is away from home/University but in the UK you will still be able to get NHS care from a local GP or walk-in centre. If you are going elsewhere, you must ensure that you have adequate insurance cover, normally provided as part of a travel insurance package - see below for guidance on what your travel insurance should include. Students can ask to be covered under the University's policy which is free of cost. Applicants for the Turing scheme are obliged to register for this insurance: **bath.ac.uk/guides/insurance-services**. Some cover may be provided by the Global Health Insurance Scheme, however this will not provide the same level of cover as the NHS and consequently, travel insurance is essential. Apply for a UK Global Health Insurance Card (GHIC) - **gov.uk/global-health-insurance-card**

What if you lose your belongings?
If you have any personal possessions insurance, you should ensure that it covers you away from your normal home. If you are going overseas, all travel insurance policies include some cover for personal possessions.

What if you are injured whilst on your placement?
In the UK, your placement provider is obliged to treat you as an employee, and is therefore legally required to have Employers' Liability Insurance or equivalent arrangements for self-insurance (such as the NHS, Police and some others), so if you think you might want to make a personal injury claim, you know there will be insurance in place to pay that claim.

Outside the UK, the position is not so straightforward, which is why the University will ask an overseas placement provider to confirm whether they have insurance, which covers their liability for students on placement.

Car insurance
Any student on placement, whether situated at the University or with an external employer, must make sure that their own car insurance policy covers business use. Most car insurance policies allow individuals to travel to and from a normal place of business as standard, but many have restrictions regarding using a private vehicle for other business activities during the working day. It is the responsibility of the student to ensure that the provisions of their insurance policy are sufficient and appropriate for their requirements whilst on placement.

Transport for London

If your upcoming placement is in London, and you will be living in a London Borough for the duration, you will be able to apply for an 18+ Student Oyster photocard. The system for doing this is as follows:

Please Note: You can only apply once you have started your placement and are living in the London address you have for the duration of your placement

- Go to **photocard.tfl.gov.uk/tfl/showLogon.do**
- Create a web account as instructed then follow the instructions on the 18+ Student Oyster photocard section
- You will find the University of Bath in the drop down menu of the window that says 'Enter the name of your university, college, school, or establishment'
- **Before submitting** this application you must be resident in your London address as the Oyster Card will be sent there
- Do NOT click the option for "Doing a placement year". Select no as Bath is registered with TFL and the process is faster.
- Also, **before submitting** the application, you must have updated your term-time address on SAMIS. Failure to do so will result in your application being declined

Please note, if you are living outside the TFL zone but are travelling into London, you are **NOT** eligible for a Student Oyster Card.

For those of you who have already got an application in the system and have been declined please do the following:

- Do not re-submit until you have started your placement and are living in your London address
- At that point, if you have not done so already, update your term time address on SAMIS to your London address
- Once you have updated SAMIS you can re-submit

If you have a query or believe your application has been declined in error please email **studentservices@bath.ac.uk**

6 Overseas placements

To make sure that you get the most out of your time abroad, research the country you are going to thoroughly and talk to students who have been before.

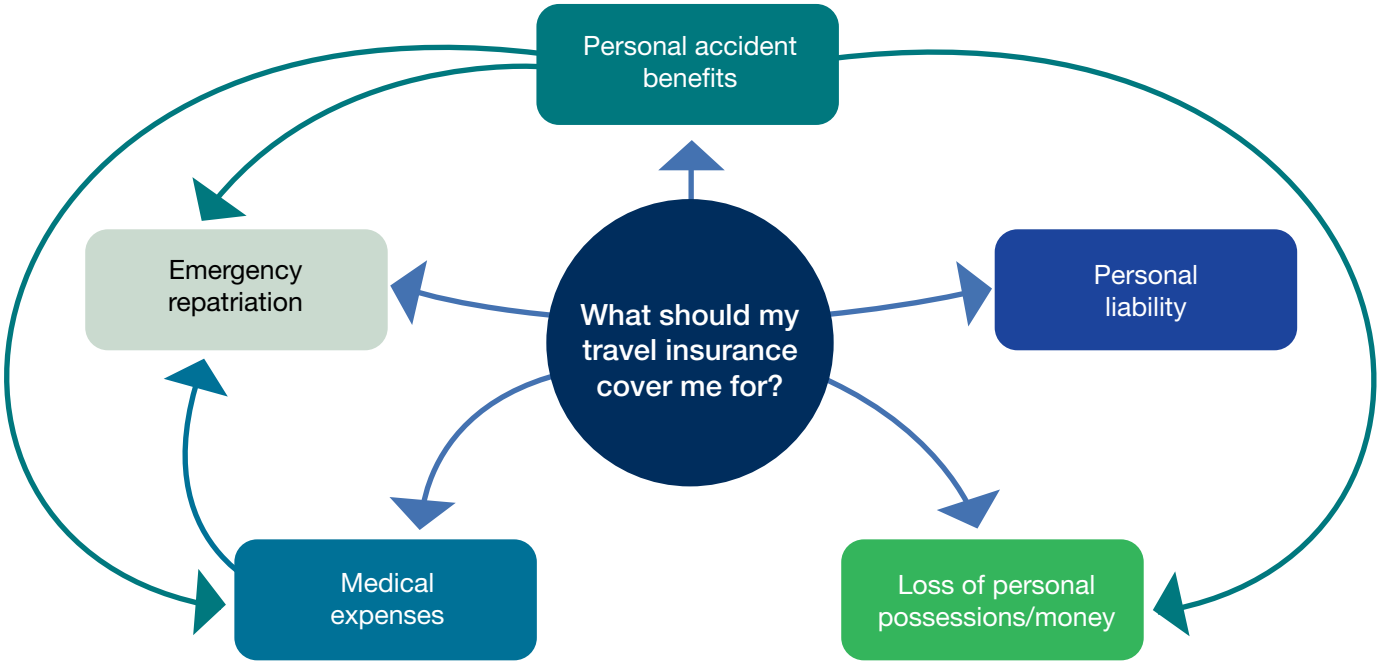
You are responsible for your own insurance when working or studying abroad.

Insurance and GHIC

UK students who will be working or studying abroad should apply for a Global Health Insurance Card (GHIC). With this you may be entitled to medical care at reduced cost or sometimes free. You will need to apply online. For instructions, please follow Applying for healthcare cover abroad (GHIC and EHIC) - **nhs.uk/using-the-nhs/healthcare-abroad/apply-for-a-free-uk-global-health-insurance-card-ghic** EU students should apply for their country's equivalent of the EHIC (European Health Insurance Card).

All students whether UK/EU or non-EU residents, and whether going to EU or non-EU countries, must take out a full-year travel insurance policy with medical cover. If you are doing a work placement you must ensure that it is valid for work abroad. You can either purchase a University of Bath Student Travel Cover or you can purchase your own separate comprehensive insurance policy. Please note that all Turing Funding recipients are required to sign up to the University of Bath Travel Cover, as other policies cannot be accepted: **store.bath.ac.uk/product-catalogue/items-for-staff-students-and-alumni/travel-cover**

The extent of cover and list of exclusions varies from one insurer to another - you should read the exclusions



and decide if they might apply to your circumstances. For example,

- Exclusion of cover if you are working - standard travel insurance does not normally cover work placements
- Life style exclusions (such as excluding claims whilst under the influence of drugs/alcohol)
- Activity exclusions (some insurers idea of "dangerous activities" might include skiing or motorcycling, not just sky diving)
- Pregnancy exclusions (some policies won't let you travel within 3 months of the due date or may not cover the baby if it is born early)
- Existing condition exclusions (most policies won't cover you for existing medical conditions and related prescription costs)

Safety abroad

Foreign & Commonwealth Office

You must consult the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office web site: **gov.uk/government/organisations/foreign-commonwealth-office** which is regularly updated and has comprehensive information on all countries, including advice on the current political situation, and warnings of unrest and crime blackspots. It also gives travellers' tips and information on vaccinations.

Responding to incidents overseas
In certain circumstances whilst on placement overseas, you may find yourself affected by an emergency situation such as a natural disaster, a political/social crisis, major accidents or terrorist activity.

The University will want to confirm your safety and ensure that support is available to you, should you need it. The University has a procedure in place for responding to significant incidents overseas: **bath.ac.uk/publications/procedure-for-responding-to-significant-incidents-overseas**

You will have been given a number of University contact details by your placements office for use in an emergency whilst you are away. If a situation arises, you will need to contact your Placement Manager (team contact details listed on page 4 of this handbook) who is your Key Contact Officer. You may also contact the University using the 24-hour Security number: **+44 (0) 1225 385349**.

Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office Travel Update Service

Before departure from the UK, please ensure that you have subscribed to the FCDO Country-Specific Travel Advice update service relevant to the country you will be living in. This will alert you to any urgent news relating to security risk, political unrest, natural disasters etc., and provide relevant advice. Subscribe by clicking on the web page below and then requesting the email alert: **gov.uk/government/policies/british-nationals-overseas/email-signup**

The risk assessment meeting provided for you by the University before your departure will have helped to familiarise you with the type of hazards you are likely to face on placement. Do re-read the risk assessment form to remind yourself of the advice given. Do not travel alone or on foot if it is dark or late. Let someone know where you are going and when you expect to return. Carry a mobile phone, identification and a personal alarm with you. A small high-powered torch is useful.

Personal behaviour

It is your responsibility not to cause unnecessary offence and distress to the people of the communities in which you live and work. On arrival in the country, it is most important to find out as soon as possible about local customs and etiquette. You are likely to be judged on the basis of your appearance and first impressions are important, often to a greater extent than in your home country. If in doubt, dress as smartly as your circumstances allow and your reason suggests. It will do less damage to your standing in the community to have to relax your dress code later than if you have to overcome an unfavourable first impression resulting from what is considered inappropriate dress.

Politics and religion

In some countries, it is best not to express strong views on politics or religion. You should be wary of entering into political discussions. Be particularly careful of commenting on local politics and on no account become actively involved. You will most likely be welcome to practice your own faith as long as you also respect the official religion and do not attempt to proselytise.

Breaking the law

You should obviously take all reasonable precautions to ensure that you do not break the laws of the country where you are working. If you do so inadvertently and find yourself in trouble over it, you should inform the Placement Manager as soon as possible, giving an honest account of the circumstances.

The University cannot accept responsibility for payment of fines or take any action which evades the legal process. We would draw your attention to the laws most countries have concerning black market currency dealing and drug use and trafficking. Students should also be aware that in many countries homosexuality remains illegal with severe consequences for people whose lifestyle attracts the attention of the authorities or local community.

Money

It's not always necessary to open a bank account overseas, but it is more convenient. As it may take longer than you think to set up the account, you should ensure that you have easy instant access to sufficient money to cover your living expenses for two months.

Keep a note of the numbers you will need to report credit card theft and any other emergencies. It is a good idea to keep a copy of these and keep them in separate places as well as leave a copy with a trusted family member or friend.

Keep only a small amount of cash on you in case of theft, and have cash in several different pockets. Invest in an International Student Card (ISIC) - it costs approximately £12 and allows many student discounts and acts as proof of identity in many countries. The ISIC can be an additional part of the Totum Card and it might be cheaper to buy the two from £14.99, see details at: **isic.org** or **thesubath.com/nusextra**

Turing funding

Eligible students can apply for the Turing Scheme for international placements and exchanges. Information on how and when to apply will be released on the Turing Moodle course in the Summer.

Turing Scheme Moodle Course
moodle.bath.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=59887

Details are available from the University International Relations Office
www.bath.ac.uk/campaigns/the-turing-scheme/

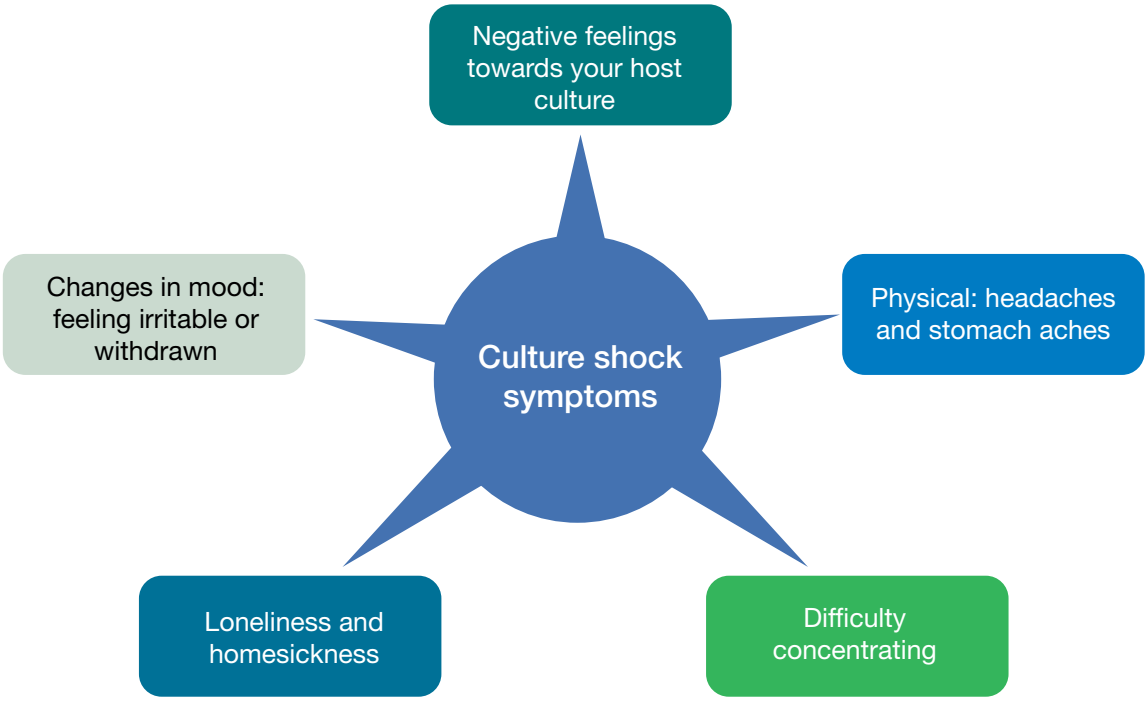
You can direct your questions to **turing@bath.ac.uk**

TURING SCHEME

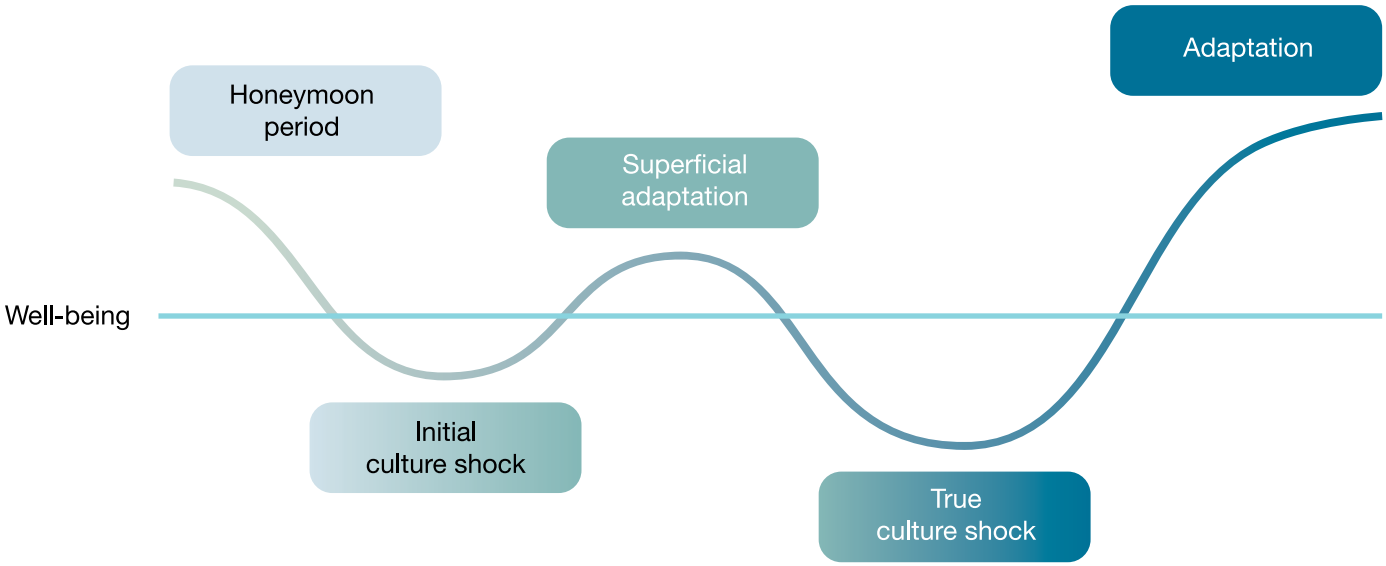
The UK's global programme to study and work abroad

Cultural awareness

Culture shock
The signs and how you can support yourself:



While you are living abroad you may experience certain emotional reactions to your new environment. You should be aware of the possibility that your initial excitement might be followed by a feeling of rejection towards the new environment. You may start to miss the people who are important in your life. Cultural differences which may affect you include food, language, dress, social behaviour as well as climate. These feelings are completely normal and are commonly referred to as “culture shock”. It is important to remember that these feelings will pass as you adjust to the new culture.



Positive aspects of culture shock
Experiencing culture shock can be a significant learning experience, which will make you more aware of aspects of your own culture as well as the new culture you have entered. It will give you valuable skills that will serve you well now and in the future and which will be part of the benefit of a placement or study abroad.

What can you do to help yourself if you're experiencing culture shock?

Remind yourself that culture shock is a normal part of adjusting to life in a different culture. With time, the symptoms should pass.

It can help to discuss what you are missing at home.

- Maintain regular contact with family and friends by telephone/email/letters.
- Keep familiar things around you, such as photos.
- If you miss a certain type of food, try to find out if there is anywhere you can buy it.

Socialising can make a difference.

- Try to develop friendships with local people so that you can learn more about one another's culture.
- Talk to other international students to share experiences and explore coping strategies.
- Get out and about and experience the place you are living in. Join a club or society.

Persevere if you are experiencing difficulty with your language skills. It may feel very tiring constantly having to listen to and speak in a different language. Ask people to repeat what they have said.

Speak to someone, preferably locally.

Speak to a trusted individual; your local employer, colleagues, friends or family, or the Placements Team.

Tips for going abroad

Mobile phones

Check with your mobile phone provider if they charge roaming fees. In some circumstances it may be cheaper to buy a local sim card.

Public holidays

Do not assume that UK holidays apply. In the USA, for example, Good Friday is not a public holiday, and neither is Easter Monday.

Details or national holidays around the world can be found here:

timeanddate.com/holidays

Travel

If you have a driving licence, take it with you or get an International Driving Permit. There may be restrictions on hiring a car if you are under 25 years old. Keep your licence and insurance with you at all times to avoid on the spot fines. It's always best to check the local Highway Code.

Resident's permit

On arrival, check with your employer how to go about getting a resident's permit as many countries outside the UK require you to have one. There is often a small amount of bureaucracy attached, but nothing that a good phrasebook and a bit of patience can't solve!

Illness on placement

If you become ill whilst on placement you must notify your employer (by phone, not by email) as soon as possible on the day. Students on a tier 4/student visa who are absent for more than 14 days must request an authorised absence through SAMIS:

bath.ac.uk/samis

Healthcare abroad

Before you leave the UK, you ought to find out what the country's procedure is for medical and dental treatment.

The NHS provide useful online guides to healthcare by country:

nhs.uk/NHSEngland/Healthcareabroad/countryguide/Pages/EEAcountries.aspx

Guidance on vaccinations is essential if you are travelling further afield:

nhs.uk/conditions/travel-vaccinations

Important documents

Do not keep all your important documents together and be vigilant in airports, clubs and crowded places. Photocopy your passport and insurance documents. Leave one set of copies at home and take one with you. In many countries it is a legal requirement to carry your passport or ID card with you at all times, you should research this before departure.

Document checklist

- [ ] Passport, Visa (will be stamped in passport or an electronic visa)
- [ ] Tickets and travel documents
- [ ] A copy of your Birth Certificate (may be useful)
- [ ] Spare passport sized photos
- [ ] Driving Licence, International Driving Permit
- [ ] Global Health Insurance Card, GHIC
- [ ] Travel insurance documents, copies of passport and travel insurance documents
- [ ] Small amount of local money for when you arrive and for initial expenses such as hostel etc
- [ ] Proof of student status, ISIC card (allows many student discounts)
- [ ] Sort out source of emergency funds,
- [ ] Contract or letter of confirmation
- [ ] Correspondence from/to your employer and details of any contacts
- [ ] Accommodation address details
- [ ] Copy of your transcripts, CV, etc
- [ ] Important phone number

7 Being professional and effective

Punctuality

Punctuality (or rather lack of punctuality!) is one element of the placement that is frequently commented upon by placement providers.

Top tips for punctuality

Be aware of your commute time.
Know where you need to be e.g., another venue.

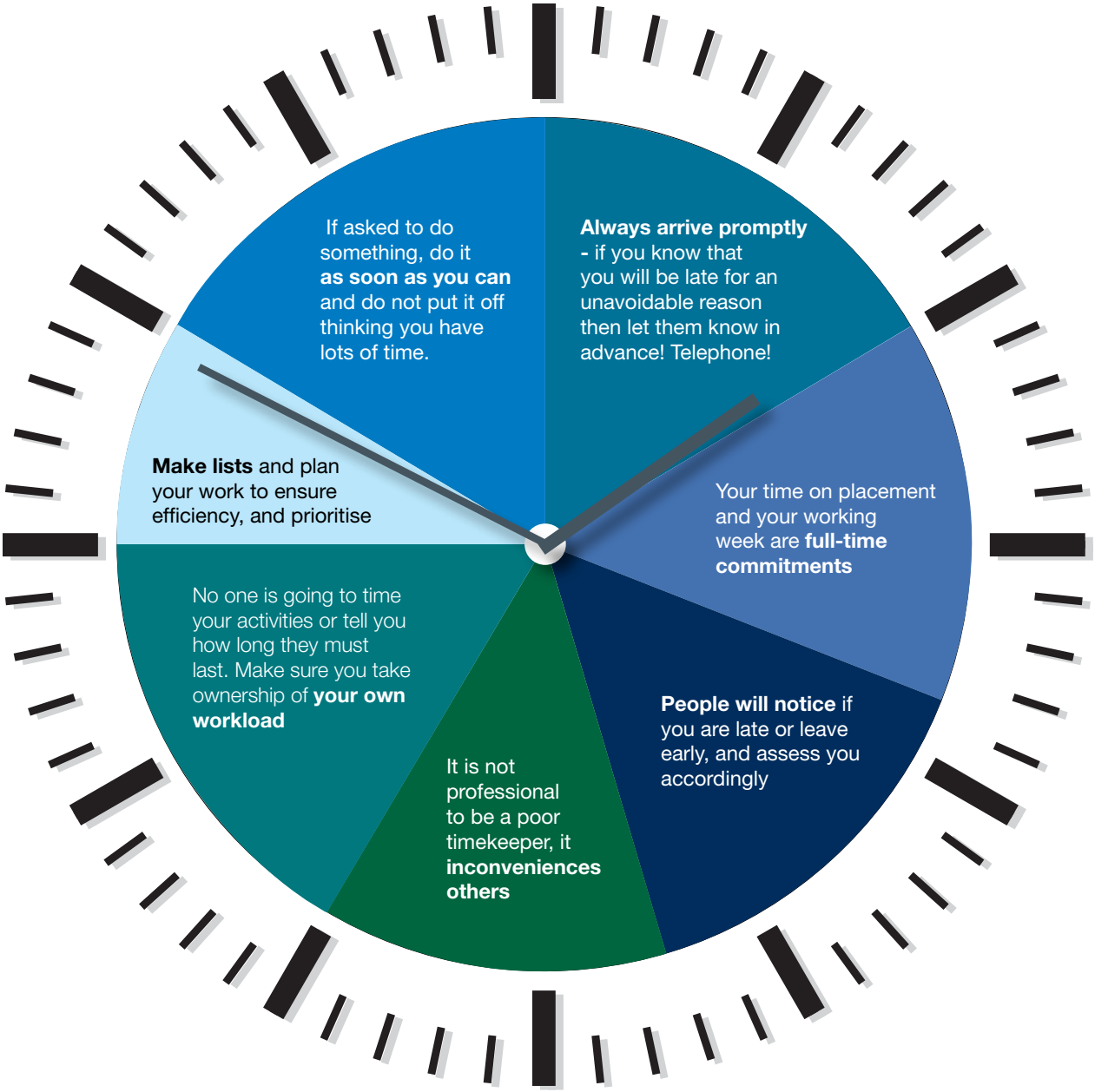
Full working week:
Normally about 30-40 hours and likely to include an upaid lunch break.

Flexi-time?
This may be an option but make sure you **discuss this with your supervisor.**

Know where you need to be eg. another venue. If you think you may be late, inform your Line Manager. Make sure your **supervisor is aware** of your whereabouts.

It is important to discuss the hours you work, and the tasks you do to achieve a balance, especially if you feel there is a danger of becoming overloaded. You should aim to take a lunch break every day and plan time to relax outside of your working day.

Time management



Forms of address

Since you are a junior member of the team, you should be formal in your address to more senior members until told otherwise (calling them Professor, Dr, etc., or Mr or Ms). It is advisable to ask individuals how they wish to be addressed.

- Do not be over-familiar at the outset
- It is better to be too formal, than too informal and then cause offence
- Ask at the beginning how you should answer the telephone and what your signature should be on the email
- Remember always to be formal in emails and letters
- Do not address anyone by their first name unless you know them and you have been told it is all right
- Think carefully about the information you are communicating and ensure it is clear
- Do not use colloquialisms or 'friendly' terms and sign off with 'Yours sincerely / Yours faithfully' in letters or 'Kind regards' or 'Many thanks' in emails

Technology, internet and email

Most of you will have access to the Internet at work, but this is supplied for work use only. Remember these key rules:

- Check whether your employer has a policy on the use of social media. Think about your digital footprint as well, don't write any negative comments on your own social media or placement review websites that are publically accessible
- The tone of your messages should reflect your professional status
- Be very careful with the wording and read messages again before sending
- Do not download or pass on any material that is not related to work
- Remember that email is not secure and that any emails that you send can be retrieved and read by the employer, even if you have deleted them
- Before you start work, you should check you online presence across your social media accounts. You may want to consider making your accounts private to maintain a professional image whilst on placement.

A.I. in the workplace

The use and implementation of A.I. is dynamic and changes rapidly, varying from company to company. It's important to check if your employer has a policy in place on the use of A.I. For many industries, there may be significant cautions and protocols in place to maintain a strong stance on data privacy and protection of intellectual property. If there are no company-wide policies, it is still advisable to discuss this with your manager. Please be aware that a data breach could be a sackable offence

Mobile phones

You should not keep your mobile phone on your desk or answer your phone during the working day without permission.

Dress code

- You should conform to the standard of dress and behaviour appropriate to your employer/department
- If in doubt - ask your supervisor about the dress code
- Some placements may involve official engagements (e.g. attending court where a dress code is prescribed)
- You should aim to always look professional, smart and tidy

Discipline and conduct

Students must conform to employers' disciplinary procedures and Health and Safety Regulations as well as the Placements Code of Conduct.

Remember that whilst on placement you may be exposed to sensitive information relating to clients, other companies, or to your employer. It is very important to maintain strict levels of confidentiality at all times.

Any students that conduct themselves in an unacceptable manner, and consequently receive a poor employer appraisal are at risk of failing the Placements unit.

Intercultural awareness

Intercultural competence can be described as the ability to communicate effectively and appropriately with people from different cultural backgrounds.

Knowledge	about other cultures and other their behaviours
Empathy	understanding the feelings and needs of other people
Self-confidence	knowledge of one's own desires, strengths, weaknesses, and emotional stability
Cultural identity	knowledge of one's own culture

Within language, people from **different cultural backgrounds** may use **different speech styles**, which may lead not only to confusion, but also to misunderstanding of intent. These differences can quickly lead to frustration and friction. Simple communication can be easily misinterpreted.

Email is widely used as the first tool of communication within business, and **can easily cause offense**. The format, formal/informal tone, contents (some cultures may accept jokes, slang etc in emails, whereas in other cultures this is unacceptable), how brief, how detailed, grammar differences, are all aspects and dimensions that can have unexpected impact on communication and relationships through emails.

For successful intercultural communication, leadership, and collaboration you need a strong awareness of your own cultural identity. You must understand the importance of intercultural skills through **developing cultural intelligence** and **intercultural competence**. You must be able to adapt without losing the strengths of your own identify and core values.

Employers expect you to ask questions to ensure understanding and make learning more efficient. It is anticipated that you will **put your ideas forward**, using your **initiative** to solve problems and provide solutions. You are required to keep the team abreast / aware / up-to-date and actively **engage** in project discussions. Think carefully about who you are communicating with and adapt accordingly.

Tackling problems on placement

There is a lot you can do to make your placement a worthwhile learning experience. Some placements are well structured and managed but others may lack structure, at least initially.

Lack of work

- Organisations accustomed to taking placement students may produce a written work programme and/or a set of learning objectives for your placement, or ask you to produce some objectives yourself which they can endeavour to meet. If this is not provided and you are unclear about what is expected, then ask - this gives you the opportunity to input ideas/suggestions

Inadequate training for the job

- In many cases the only way to learn is "on the job" but if you feel more training is needed in the early stages of your placement then talk to your supervisor

Poor communication

- If you feel things are not being clearly explained or that the person is assuming you have prior knowledge you do not have, it is much better to ask questions rather than pretend you know what they want and inwardly panic

Queries about your work

- Make the most of your relationship with your supervisor, it is their role and responsibility to support you and answer your queries
- It may also give you a chance to go on a training course or "shadow" someone to find out more
- Clarification early on saves a lot of mistakes and unhappiness

Receiving feedback

- Take comments on board and reflect on them for the future as a mechanism for improvement

Becoming involved

- If you have not been invited to some meetings, ask if you can attend them in the future, but if not allowed don't take it personally – not everyone is involved in everything, there may be issues of confidentiality
- Make the most of the knowledge of others who are more experienced than you; most people should be quite willing, time permitting, to explain things to you to help you see the wider context of work you are doing

Mundane work

- Remember that the work may appear mundane at the beginning but this can be an important basis for later, so do not be discouraged
- You may need to prove your competence before being given more responsibility, but if you feel you are not being used to your full potential then decide what action to take
- Your approach to completing this percentage of your work will have a significant effect on the success of the outcome

Difficult people

Occasionally, some colleagues may appear unfriendly and unhelpful. Remember to:

- Keep your calm
- Always be polite and professional
- Sometimes situations or personal factors can influence someone to behave inappropriately towards you
- Familiarise yourself with the relevant policies and procedures in the organisation which will guide you in dealing with such situations

Remember to listen

- You can learn a lot by asking questions
- Remember to learn when to speak and when to listen

Speak to your placement supervisor about any training you feel you may require and **remember it is your responsibility to ask for advice and support** concerning situations you are unsure about. **Communicate** with your supervisor and with the Placements Tutor.

Tackling problems and troubleshooting

How to discuss problems with your supervisor
- It is important to be **tactful** and **diplomatic**
- **Choose time carefully** and arrange an appointment
- **Be well prepared** for the discussion
- **Be positive** - do not just go along with a list of complaints and criticisms
- Remember your expectations or interpretation of the tasks may be different from your supervisor's (Some supervisors make the mistake of overselling the placement at the interview stage)
- At the end of the discussion it is worth ensuring that the proposed action is recorded in writing (you can do this) and agreed with your supervisor to avoid any misunderstandings

A review meeting with your supervisor can establish clearer lines of communication between you for the future. Do not be afraid of making suggestions for improving or developing the scope of the placement - most people welcome the display of interest and initiative, providing your request is reasonable and realistic, of course. Handled in a positive way, a review meeting of this kind will usually result in a better programme and will earn you the respect of the supervisor and team as well.

Remember the Placement Office are available to offer support and guidance at any time.

Actions to take if things do not improve:

1. If things do not improve immediately, be patient
2. Try not to let your motivation diminish
3. If nothing improves despite tactful reminders, the next step is **to telephone or email your Placements Office/Tutor** to talk things through - if you are unsure how to tackle the situation, do this first, rather than upset people by taking inappropriate action

You should make the first approach yourself. Remember, no one will know you have problems if you do not raise the matter with your supervisor, and things are often easily resolvable.

Changing your placement organisation is rare and should only be a very last resort. This must only be done in consultation with your Placements Office/Tutor. Identifying problems early on and ensuring that they are addressed should prevent this situation.

Your placement as a learning experience:
On a positive note, **tackling problems can be valuable experience in developing interpersonal skills**. Even if your placement is not ideal you will find, on reflection that you have learned a lot both about yourself and the world of work, management styles, culture, etc. Keeping a positive attitude is important. Remember that how you conduct yourself will affect others and those who work with you will want to enjoy having you in their department.

Finally, most students agree that 'a placement is what you make of it' and you 'get out as much as you put in'.

Problem checklist

1 Identify the problem	Is it due to: • The nature of the job? • Supervisor's misunderstandings of your needs? • How you have been behaving?
2 Establish what you want	• Your aims, what do you want to get out of the job? Which topics/areas are you most interested in? • Would it be possible to be seconded to a particular area/person/ department? • Do you require further training or help? • Are there any projects you can identify that it would be possible for you to do?
3 Decide who to talk to	• Supervisor/manager/immediate boss/mentor or colleague • Placements Office/Tutor • Personnel Officer • Student Services
4 Raise the issues	• You could suggest a more balanced programme of work. You could ask for more variety and work in a different area/ different project • You could ask for training or to attend courses/meetings

Be clear:
- Clarify your objectives
- Try to arrange regular appraisals with your supervisor to ensure that all parties are happy
- Do not just complain without offering any alternatives or possible solutions
- If you have been at fault then do not be afraid to admit that and start afresh with a different attitude

If necessary take the initiative and arrange for an early visit by the visiting tutor - this is often instrumental in sorting out difficulties and makes the host organisation think about the work you are doing and re-appraise it.

Liaise with your Placements Office/Tutor to keep them informed of progress or problems

Hidden meanings
You may find whilst you are on placement that not everyone is direct in saying what they want or how they want something to be done. For example, rather than directly telling you to do something, they may be more subtle with their suggestions and offer comments such as:

'You might like to….'

'Have you considered . . .'

'Perhaps you could just…..'

These are all implied commands and actually mean that most likely they will be trying to help you to improve, so please do take their comments on board!

In summary….
To resolve any problems during placement you should: **BE ACTIVE - BE POSITIVE - BE PROMPT**

Seek help if required. Most importantly, see the placement as a unique experience, get the most out of it and

ENJOY IT! it is a unique opportunity, don't waste it.

At the end of your placement

End of placement checklist:

- [ ] Submitted all required assessment materials by the due date and attended any debriefings
- [ ] Complied with any terms and conditions that still apply after the placement has ended
- [ ] Reflected and evaluated on your placement and prepared to share your experiences with potential new placement students
- [ ] Arrange for your email to have a bounce back message added for a set period after you leave, adding the next students or other contact email.

Returning to university

Remember that returning to being a student and undertaking assignments and exams is very different to placement.

It is advisable that you make arrangements for accommodation well in advance of your return to University. The Students' Union web pages offer advice and tips on finding accommodation **bathstudentpad.co.uk/Accommodation**

Your year on placement may well have influenced the direction your final year takes and your view of a future career.

Further experiences
You may feel after your placement you would like to get some additional experience. Summer internships are advertised by the Careers Team on MyFuture: **myfuture.bath.ac.uk** and further advice is available via **bath.ac.uk/careers**

Please be aware that the timing of Summer Internships may clash with your main placement and therefore you may need permission to finish early.

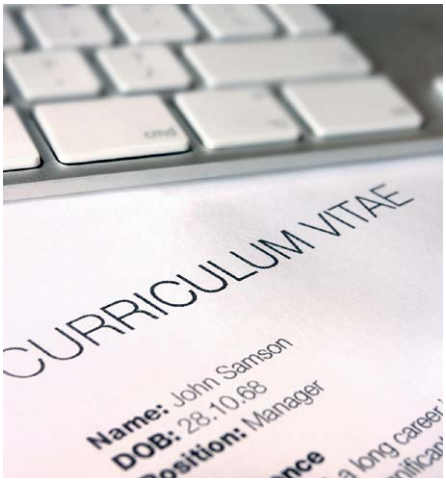
Updating your CV and getting careers guidance
Your placement may have inspired ideas for future careers or further study. Take time to update your CV and add your placement.

Maximise your placement, it was a substantial period of time working in a professional environment:

- Add all tasks in which you were involved, responsibilities and skills acquired
- Do not be shy of stating your achievements
- The experience working in your placement will set you above many other students

The Careers Team has information about courses and jobs and you can speak to a Careers Consultant before you return to Bath to help you get ahead of schedule.

Some graduate employers open their application schedules as early as July before the final year, so it is advisable to prepare your CV in advance.



UNIVERSITY OF BATH